

Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος (ὁ Σοφιστής)

Antiphon the Sophist on Truth and Human Nature

eul_aid: brc

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)
Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)
Format: [Συναγωγή](#) [Collection](#)
Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Antiphon the Sophist was an Athenian intellectual active in the late 5th century BCE, during the Classical period. He was part of the Sophist movement, teachers who offered instruction in rhetoric and virtue. His identity is a subject of scholarly debate. He has traditionally been conflated with another Athenian named Antiphon, who was a speechwriter and politician. Many modern scholars now distinguish them as separate individuals based on differences in their writings and ancient testimonies, though some sources maintain they could be the same person.

His surviving works are fragmentary, known from papyrus discoveries and quotations by later authors. They include philosophical treatises such as *On Truth*, which argues for a distinction between human laws and natural justice, and *On Concord*, which advocates for social harmony. Other attributed works are the *Politicus*, a political treatise, and a work on the Interpretation of Dreams. A set of model courtroom speeches called the *Tetralogies* is also associated with the name Antiphon; these are often linked to the speechwriter, but their educational nature connects them to Sophistic teaching.

Antiphon the Sophist is significant for his early contributions to moral and political thought. His arguments in *On Truth* provide a radical exploration of the conflict between societal convention and natural advantage, a key theme in Sophistic philosophy that later thinkers like Plato engaged with. The *Tetralogies*, regardless of their exact authorship, are historically important as the earliest surviving examples of full Athenian judicial oratory and were likely used to teach rhetorical technique. The ongoing debate about his identity makes him a central figure for understanding the links between abstract philosophy, professional rhetoric, and politics in ancient Athens.

Works (4)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On Human Nature and Barbarians](#) · 24 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On Nature and Justice](#) · 155 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On Truth](#) · 140 passages
- [Μαρτυρίαι](#) · [Testimonies](#) · 9 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- [Ἀχιλλεὺς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς](#) · [Achilles Tattius of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- [Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός](#) · [Aelian of Praeneste](#) · 4 works

- Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος · Aelius Aristides of Smyrna · 3 works
- Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς · Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus · 1 work
- Αἴλιος Θεών ὁ σοφιστής · Aelius Theon the Sophist · 1 work
- Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς · Alcidamas of Elaea · 1 work
- Ἀλκίφρων ὁ Σοφιστής · Alciphron the Sophist · 1 work
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου · Alexander Son of Numenius · 2 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Alexander the Ephesian Poet · 1 work
- Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος · Amphicrates Atheniensis · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον · Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius · 2 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος · Antiphon of Athens · 9 works